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Google launched Google Earth with new 3D imagery for Android at Google's I/O developer conference. <http://dgit.in/LzPV2o>



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PIMP MY DESKTOP

Rainmeter and Conky let you customize your Windows or Linux desktop to your liking

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Computer desktops, apart from being a quick way to access your files and applications, are also an open canvas to show off your creativity. Many desktop customisation tools allow you to display virtually any information right on your desktop in an aesthetic manner. These tools can display important information at a glance, including time, weather updates, unread email count, the currently playing music track or even your to-do list. Here we give you a glimpse into Rainmeter for Windows, and Conky for Linux, two highly versatile tools for customizing your desktop.

Conky on Linux

If you're the kind of person who isn't content with the default desktop provided by your distribution and wants to tweak it to your liking, Conky is a tool that should fit your bill. It is capable of displaying any

type of system information right on your desktop. This can include things like the CPU or memory usage, your current battery state, disk space or even things such as the weather or the currently playing music track. This is because Conky is also capable of displaying the shell output of any script, a powerful feature with endless possibilities. As an example, you can write a short script to display your Twitter stream or the current trending topics for your region. The layout and design of Conky is completely customizable, and in this short tutorial, we'll show you how to set it up and customise it to your liking.

1. Installation: Conky should be available in your distribution's package manager. If you're using Ubuntu or a derivative (Kubuntu, Xubuntu, Lubuntu or even Linux Mint) you can install conky using the command:

```
sudo apt-get install conky
```

Arch Linux users can use the command `sudo pacman -S conky`.

After installation, if you run the command 'Conky' from a terminal, you'll see an instance of Conky on your desktop with some information being displayed. This isn't quite as feature-filled or nice looking as we'd like it to be, so let's go ahead and fix that.



Conky variable showing time, date, and weather info on the desktop

2. Configuration: Conky is controlled by a single configuration file, `.conkyrc`, found in the user's home directory. (If you want to use a different file, you'll have to manually specify the file with its path using `conky -c /path/to/file`.)

The configuration file is divided into two parts. The first (upper) part describes the behaviour, placement and general appearance of your Conky window using variables. Most of the variable names should be self explanatory, you can learn about some of the important ones from the box.

At the bottom, you'll see another section, beginning with the word 'TEXT'. This is where you specify what type of information should be displayed on your Conky setup, including the layout, design and general appearance. You can also include a call to an lua script that can draw widgets, or make Conky display the output of an external script. Any static text that is typed here will appear as it is, and Conky includes a wide range of variables that can display system info. We'll show you some commonly used Conky variables using a simple example, but for a complete list of variables that Conky can display, visit <http://dgit.in/RON9rU>

In the example above, we've displayed the time, date, weather and some system information like the battery percentage, CPU and memory usage. The Gmail unread count and the weather conditions are displayed via an external (Python)

COMMON CONFIGURATION OPTIONS FOR CONKY

update_interval	Time in seconds before Conky refreshes itself.
alignment	The alignment of the window with respect to the screen. Possible values are top_right, top_left, bottom_right and bottom_left.
gap_x, gap_y	Distance from the edge of the screen in pixels. This distance is measured from the edge specified above.
maximum_width	Maximum width of the window in, measured in pixels.
own_window_type	Describes the behaviour of the window. 'desktop' causes Conky to be treated as any other window, while 'override' causes Conky to appear as a part of the desktop.
own_window_hints	This describes the appearance of Conky. It can take a number of values, separated by a comma. Possible values include undecorate (which removes window decoration like the title bar or the minimize/maximize/close buttons), sticky (which fixes Conky's position on the screen), skip_taskbar (which prevents Conky from showing up on the taskbar) and skip_pager (which prevents Conky from showing up as a preview on your workspace thumbnails)